Waste and Hazardous Substances Policy

This policy seeks to transform all sectors of the Aotearoa New Zealand economy into a circular economy in which the production of unnecessary waste and hazardous substances is eliminated and, where this is not possible, they are effectively managed through reuse and recycling, safely, effectively, and responsibly, to ensure the wellbeing of current and future generations.

Vision

All activities eliminate waste, circulate resources, and regenerate nature.

Values and Principles

- *Honour Te Tiriti o Waitangi*: Tangata whenua have primary decision-making power over the elimination and reduction of waste and hazardous substances production, as well as their management and disposal, and all decisions in this area show respect to the taonga of te taiao.
- *Ecological Wisdom*: Material growth should be limited, such that waste production is avoided or redirected for use in a circular economy.
- *Social Responsibility*: The management of waste and hazardous substances should not further disadvantage or burden marginalised groups within or outside Aotearoa New Zealand.
- *Appropriate Decision-Making*: Decisions regarding the management of waste should be based on mātauranga Māori and western science, and determined in partnership with whānau, hapū and iwi.
- *Non-Violence*: A precautionary approach to hazardous material should be taken to ensure that no person, ecological environment or native species is harmed by the production, management or disposal of hazardous materials.

Strategic Priorities

The Green Party's strategic goals include:

> *"Our nation will be in transition to a zero waste economy, where single use plastics are largely eliminated, wasteful consumption is ended, and all-of-lifecycle product stewardship is in place across the economy."*

Actions in this policy that will help achieve this include:

- Establishing a Tiriti-based national circular economy strategy that sets out a clear pathway for the phasing out of landfills (1.2.3)

- Promoting thoughtful and moderated consumption and restricting advertising that promotes hyperconsumption (1.5.2)
- Resourcing the implementation of zero-waste strategies and associated legislation (1.2.1)
- Prohibiting most single-use plastic products and non-recyclable and non-home-compostable packaging, with necessary exceptions (2.2.1)
- Developing a national resource recovery network that resources existing local solutions and replicates them in other areas (2.4.1)
- Requiring all products that include plastics and rare earth metals to be readily recyclable (2.5.1)
- Leading international efforts to clean up plastic and other harmful waste from the Pacific Ocean (2.9.5)

Connected Policies

Waste management is one role of the Government in the Economy and part of protecting Biodiversity and Environmental Regeneration, Freshwater, Land Use and Soils, and Marine ecosystems. See also our policies on waste minimisation in Agriculture, Health, Housing and Sustainable Communities, and Business, and the use of waste for Energy and Trade.

Policy Positions

1. Towards A Circular Economy

Issues

Aotearoa New Zealand currently has a linear economic structure, where the production of waste and the end life of products are often not considered when making decisions about production, distribution, and use. This leads to an excessive focus on the extraction of new resources rather than the repair of products and the reuse of already available resources. It generates waste that could have been avoided, and inappropriate management and disposal of waste products. Redefining "waste" and moving towards a circular economy and closed-loop systems can create jobs and reduce our impacts on nature.

Actions

1.1. Ensure that decision-making and operational arrangements enable a Tiriti-based, just transition to a circular economy[1], by:

1.1.1. Resourcing the implementation of zero-waste strategies and associated legislation;

1.1.2. Establishing a Tiriti-based coordinating agency with a circular economy and zero-waste focus; and

[1] A *circular economy* is designed to keep materials in use and eliminate waste to landfill, guided by life-cycle and end-of-life analysis, so that products are either repaired, reused, sustainably recycled, or composted.

1.1.3. Establishing a Tiriti-based national circular economy strategy that sets out a clear pathway for the phasing out of landfills.

1.2. Affirm the tino rangatiratanga of iwi, hapū, and whānau in:

1.2.1. Decisions regarding waste elimination, management and disposal; and

1.2.2. Their role as kaitiaki, including in their efforts to protect sites such as customary food gathering areas and wāhi tapu from the negative impacts of pollution.

1.3. Legislate to increase circular economic practices, including:

1.3.1. Expanding product stewardship requirements to all products with a significant resource- and/or waste-related impact, including solar panels and batteries;

1.3.2. Requiring and supporting key sectors to work within a zero-waste, circular economy model, including food waste, health, construction, fishing, and textiles; and

1.3.3. Requiring companies to communicate to investors how, through their circular economy activities, they can provide a return on investment.

1.4. Support research and development that enables a transition to a circular economy, by:

1.4.1. Promoting innovation and investment in resource efficiency, reuse and recovery;

1.4.2. Provide business and organisational support for innovative circular economy and zero waste businesses;

1.4.3. Gathering accurate information on the volume, composition, management, and disposal of waste and hazardous substances in New Zealand; and

1.4.4. Increasing assessments of chemicals that are used in land and water ecosystems (e.g. biocides), to ensure their safety for human use, and preventing their use until such assessments have been undertaken.

1.5. Facilitate community-led circular economy initiatives and a zero-waste-to-landfill cultural shift, including by:

1.5.1. Resource Māori organisations working to support a circular economy, including kaupapa Māori-based zero waste initiatives such as Para Kore;

1.5.2. Promoting thoughtful and moderated consumption and restricting advertising that promotes hyperconsumption; and

1.5.3. Increase awareness of the role of waste management in climate change mitigation, including the contributions of different sectors.

2. Waste Streams

Issues

Resource recovery is often seen as inefficient, with recyclable or reusable products and materials sent to landfill due to cost and difficulties associated with more appropriate streaming. Waste is not yet treated as a valuable resource for use in a circular economy.

Actions

2.1. Ensure that the management and disposal of waste and hazardous substances protect ecosystems, including:

2.1.1. Treating land, soil, and water as taonga and protecting them from the discharge or inappropriate storage of waste and hazardous products;

2.1.2. Protecting wild foods in terrestrial, freshwater, and marine environments from contamination by dangerous levels of hazardous chemicals; and

2.1.3. Considering the cultural and spiritual significance of the affected land to tangata whenua.

2.2. Minimise the use of inherently polluting substances at the production and import stage, including:

2.2.1. Prohibiting most single-use plastic products and non-recyclable and non-home-compostable packaging, with necessary exceptions;

2.2.2. Setting exposure limits for hazardous substances that protect the whole human population, including the most vulnerable, and ecosystems;

2.2.3. Prohibiting hazardous substances that have non-hazardous alternatives available, based on best practice, scientific evidence, and indigenous knowledge;

2.2.4. Requiring hazardous substances to be registered for specific necessary uses in Aotearoa New Zealand; and

2.2.5. Prohibiting or restricting the use of a substance when there is emerging scientific evidence that it is causing adverse human health or environmental effects.

2.3. Maximise the useful life of purchased products by:

2.3.1. Establishing quality, efficiency, and recycling standards for all products entering or made in Aotearoa New Zealand;

2.3.2. Prohibiting planned obsolescence;

2.3.3. Legislating a right to repair;

2.3.4. Requiring manufacturers of goods sold in Aotearoa to make replacement parts, repair guides, and similar materials accessible to consumers; and

2.3.5. Funding community-based repair services.

2.4. Redirect waste streams for reuse and repurposing wherever possible across the economy, including by:

2.4.1. Developing a national resource recovery network that resources existing local solutions and replicates them in other areas;

2.4.2. Providing rural communities with local composting, repair, and reuse facilities and ensuring access to centralised or mobile waste collection services;

2.4.3. Expanding refill systems for safely collecting and reusing containers; and

2.4.4. Enabling EV batteries to be repurposed as energy storage devices.

2.5. Maximise the recycling and composting of materials that cannot be reused, including by:

2.5.1. Requiring all products that include plastics and rare earth metals to be readily recyclable;

2.5.2. Providing residential and commercial composting facilities and services for organic and compostable waste;

2.5.3. Requiring clear product labelling using common standards for "compostable" and "recyclable";

2.5.4. Enabling and encouraging the use of composting toilets, where practicable;

2.5.5. Phasing out the use of hazardous chemicals during burial proceedings, to prevent these chemicals from entering the environment; and

2.5.6. Resourcing and promoting safe greywater reuse and recycling.

2.6. Ensure that communities exposed to hazardous substances:

2.6.1. Are fully involved in the investigation and reporting of any health, community, or ecological impacts; and

2.6.2. Receive appropriate treatment and compensation.

2.7. Manage the legacy of stored waste and hazardous substances by:

2.7.1. Supporting the transition of retired landfill sites into other appropriate uses;

2.7.2. Preventing long-term ongoing pollution from old landfill sites into soil and groundwater, and protecting those that are vulnerable to flooding, erosion and sea-level rise; and

2.7.3. Remediating historical waste sites that impact soil and water health.

2.8. Manage the legacy of waste and hazardous substances that are dispersed throughout ecosystems by:

2.8.1. Resourcing efforts to remove microplastic pollution.

2.9. Take responsibility for the impact of Aotearoa New Zealand's waste on other countries and Earth systems, by:

2.9.1. Participating in and supporting a strong global plastics treaty;

2.9.2. Prohibiting the export of low-quality waste for recycling, and requiring any exports of high-quality materials to be to certified, highly efficient overseas systems;

2.9.3. Prohibiting the export of hazardous wastes except for recycling, reprocessing, or safe storage, and requiring this to be tracked;

2.9.4. Funding the recycling or return of waste that has been transported to Pacific Islands for recycling or disposal; and

2.9.5. Leading international efforts to clean up plastic and other harmful waste from the Pacific Ocean.